

Research Note: Re-architecting the Low-Level Design (LLD) Practice Loop

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1. Executive Summary

Low-Level Design (LLD) / Object-Oriented Design (OOD) is a core hiring competency for Software Engineers across top technology organizations. While Data Structures and Algorithms (DSA) benefit from mature automated practice ecosystems (e.g., LeetCode, HackerRank, Codeforces), **Low-Level Design practice remains profoundly broken.**

Learners today can read dozens of reference designs for a "Parking Lot" or "Elevator System," but when asked to produce their own design, they face an evaluative vacuum. Because software design inherently allows multiple valid architectures with distinct trade-offs, learners cannot determine whether their classes exhibit high cohesion, whether their abstractions are leaky, or whether their design will withstand evolving requirements.

This research note analyzes the cognitive hurdles of practicing LLD, critically reviews existing industry alternatives, identifies three foundational gaps, and articulates our product direction for a focused, rubric-grounded LLD practice platform.

2. The Learner Problem: Why LLD Practice is Hard

In our investigation of learner workflows and design interview preparation patterns, we identified four interconnected failure modes in the self-practice journey:

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1. Ambiguity of "Multiple Valid Truths" | 2. The "Passive Reading" Trap | 3. Evaluative Black Hole | 4. No Iterative Feedback Loop
Valid designs look like studying diagrams. "Did I violate SRP? Is my code actually coupled?" – No answer improved over 1

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2.1 The Ambiguity of "Multiple Valid Truths"

In DSA, correctness is verified through automated unit tests over boundary input/output pairs. In LLD, two entirely different designs for the same problem can both be correct, depending on which non-functional requirement is prioritized: * A parking lot using a simple List with synchronized methods is optimal for small garages. * An enterprise parking lot delegating to a ParkingStrategy (Strategy Pattern) with tiered spot types and observer-based occupancy monitors is optimal for multi-floor scale.

Without guidance, learners conflate functional completeness with design quality. They assume

that if their pseudocode compiles or "does the job," their Low-Level Design is sound.

2.2 The "Passive Reading" Illusion

Learners disproportionately consume passive resources (blogs, YouTube walkthroughs, GitHub repositories). When reading an expert's pre-baked class diagram, the design choices appear obvious in hindsight. However, during an interview or active practice session, the learner struggles to decompose requirements into distinct domain entities, define interfaces, and assign single responsibilities.

2.3 The Evaluative Black Hole

When a candidate finishes drafting an LLD solution on paper, in markdown, or in code, they encounter questions they cannot answer independently: Did I violate the Single Responsibility Principle by combining fee calculation and ticket persistence?* Is my `Vehicle` class tightly coupled to `ParkingSpot`?* What happens to my class hierarchy if an electric vehicle charging station is introduced tomorrow?* Did I add design patterns (e.g., Abstract Factory) unnecessarily when a simple factory was sufficient?*

2.4 Lack of an Iterative Delta Loop

Mastery requires feedback followed by immediate re-application. In existing workflows, learners rarely attempt a problem a second time because they have no mechanism to measure whether **Attempt 2** successfully addressed the structural flaws of **Attempt 1**.

3. Analysis of Existing Approaches & Market Tools

We benchmarked existing platforms and learning tools across four critical dimensions:

Solution	Category	Examples	Practice Model	Feedback Mechanism	Critical Gaps
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DSA Platforms	LeetCode, HackerRank	Code submission against unit test cases	Binary: Pass / Fail / Timeout / Memory	Tests runtime behavior and time complexity only. Completely blind to coupling, cohesion, SOLID, and class responsibilities.	Passive Content Platforms
Educative (Grokking OOD), YouTube channels	Static reading of reference solutions and UML diagrams	None (Self-assessment)	Learner cannot submit their own design. Encourages memorization of static solutions		

rather than problem decomposition. **Peer / Mock Platforms**Pramp, Interviewing.io1-on-1 human mock interviewsSubjective peer or interviewer notesHigh cost, scheduling overhead, and highly variable evaluator quality. Unusable for daily, iterative self-practice. **Generic LLMs**ChatGPT, Claude (Unstructured)Freeform text prompt: "Review my parking lot design"Conversational prose and uncalibrated scores ("Looks good! 8/10")Hallucinatory ratings, moving standards across turns, lack of structured rubrics, and inability to track versioned attempt history.

Key Insight on LLMs in Design Evaluation

Large Language Models exhibit deep reasoning over code and architecture, but **unconstrained LLM prompts produce deceptive evaluations**. When prompted with "Is this a good design?", an LLM tends to be sycophantic, praises superficial naming conventions, and invents random numerical scores. To be genuinely useful, the LLM must be constrained to a **deterministic, evidence-backed rubric** where every critique cites specific lines/classes from the learner's submission.

4. Key Gaps Identified

From our comparative analysis, we identified three critical unmet needs:

- 1. The Need for Objective, Rubric-Grounded Dimensions:** Evaluation must not be a single monolithic score. It must dissect a design across orthogonal dimensions: *Domain Modeling & Requirement Coverage, Single Responsibility & Cohesion, Coupling & Extensibility, and Trade-off Awareness*.
- 2. The Need for Concrete Evidence Citations:** Vague feedback like "Improve your coupling" is useless. Effective feedback must point directly to candidate artifacts: "Concern: Your *ParkingLot* class directly instantiates *FourWheelerSpot*, creating tight coupling. Suggestion: Introduce a *SpotAllocationStrategy* interface."
- 3. The Need for Attempt Versioning:** A platform must record attempt iterations ($A_1 \rightarrow A_2 \rightarrow A_3$) to track rubric score deltas, showing the learner where they gained ground.

5. Our Product Direction: A Focused Practice Platform

Rather than attempting to build an all-in-one learning management system or a heavy cloud collaboration tool, our product solves **one clear learner problem well**:

> "Give software engineers an active, focused environment to draft Low-Level Designs, receive **deterministic and rubric-grounded semantic critiques with concrete evidence citations**, and **iterate across versioned attempts**."

THE LEARNER JOURNEY | | | 1. Problem Catalog → 2. Structured Workspace → 3. Hybrid Engine | | (Curated LLD with (Entities, Interfaces, (Deterministic | | explicit constraints) Patterns, Trade-offs) + Semantic) | | | | ▼ | | 6. Progressive Retry ← 5. Attempt History ← 4. Evidence Feedback | (Delta score tracking (Audit trail of all (Rubric scores, | | against previous try) attempts & evolution) concerns, fixes) |

Core Product Principles:

1. **Curated, Constraint-Rich Problems:** 3–5 representative problems with specific business constraints, forcing learners to think through trade-offs rather than generic templates. 2. **Structured Submission Model:** Requiring explicit articulation of (a) Core Domain Entities, (b) Interfaces & Contracts, (c) Design Patterns used with justification, and (d) Key Trade-offs. 3. **Hybrid Evaluation Architecture:** Deterministic Phase*: Immediate validation of schema completeness, required entity counts, and structural integrity. Semantic Phase*: Structured rubric scoring where every score is accompanied by **Evidence, Concern, and Remediation Suggestion**. 4. **Stateful, Resilient Attempt Lifecycle:** Explicit state transitions (SUBMITTED $\rightarrow$ EVALUATING $\rightarrow$ COMPLETED / FAILED`) ensuring learner submissions are never lost and evaluation can decouple gracefully. 5. **Evolution-Ready Seams:** Clean domain boundaries allowing the addition of new submission formats (e.g., class diagrams) and new evaluator engines (e.g., static linters, human review) without rewriting the practice flow.